

**Berkeley Neighbors for Housing & Climate Action
2024 Candidate Questionnaire**

Candidate Name: Adena Ishii

District / Office being sought: Mayor of Berkeley

1. Berkeley's Housing Element lays out the city's plan for new housing construction through 2031, ensuring the city can meet its Regional Housing Needs Allocation (RHNA) of ~9,000 homes across a range of income levels.

The Housing Element commits Berkeley to a number of major policy changes in order to meet state requirements for affirmatively furthering fair housing, including citywide zoning for "missing middle" housing, a San Pablo Specific Plan, an updated Demolition Ordinance, and upzoning along North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave, among other items.

What is your view on the Housing Element and these policies? What are the most important things we need to do to implement the City's Housing Element?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around:

- a. Missing Middle housing**
- b. San Pablo specific plan**
- c. Zoning for housing in high-resource neighborhoods like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave**

Housing is a human right: My campaign calls for more housing, especially more *affordable* housing in *all* Berkeley neighborhoods. I know that housing issues disproportionately impact people of color and disabled communities, and my views on housing are framed by these issues of diversity and inclusion:

- **Remove obstacles to, and incentivize the construction of, missing middle housing**
 - *Focusing on duplexes, fourplexes, ADU's, and continuing to promote diversity in Berkeley's neighborhoods*
- **Thoughtfully and appropriately revise exclusionary rules around land-use**
 - *Focusing on density in transit corridors and missing middle housing in residential neighborhoods, with consideration for our city's history and racial inequities*
- **Strengthen tenant protections**
 - *Preserving affordable housing, preventing displacement, supporting Just Cause and Rent Stabilization protections*
- **Support long-term policies to address gentrification**
 - *Expanding access to higher education and jobs and skills training opportunities*

I support the San Pablo Specific Plan. I believe that as a community-informed plan, the vision for this stretch of San Pablo will provide more diverse housing and create a safe, vibrant, and accessible area for all Berkeleyans.

I believe upzoning in high-resource neighborhoods is a huge win for housing. There is a need for housing, particularly in transit corridors and I'm excited that Berkeley is taking the steps needed to meet the city's needs. It is critical that we build a diversity of units, particularly family-friendly units.

2. Berkeley's Climate Action Plan sets forth a goal of 80% reduction in greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by 2050. Today, the two major sources of GHG emissions in Berkeley are from gas-powered automobiles and natural gas used in buildings.

Berkeley has a variety of plans and programs intended to help address these emissions, including the Electric Mobility Roadmap and the Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy. Other related efforts include the Bicycle Plan and Pedestrian Master Plan, as well as the City's now-defunct natural gas ban on new buildings. Upcoming policy initiatives include the Berkeley Building Electrification and Just Transition Pilot Program, Measure GG, the Bay Area Air Quality Management District's regional ban on new NOx-emitting appliances, and more.

What is your view on the Climate Action Plan and these strategies? What are the most important things we need to do to address greenhouse gas emissions?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around how Berkeley can reduce emissions from transportation and buildings, and how we should align the climate transition with our other goals as a city.

I support the principles in the Berkeley Vision 2050 framework (approved by voters through Measure R in 2018) – a 30-year plan to identify and guide the implementation of climate-smart, technologically advanced, integrated, and efficient infrastructure to support a safe, vibrant, and resilient future for Berkeley. I believe it's time to build on the Vision 2050 plan, revamping it to see what is feasible, what we should continue, and what is worth funding.

Similarly, Berkeley's current Climate Action Plan is 15 years out of date, last published in June 2009. As our climate priorities have shifted in recent years, I will encourage an update of this plan, relaunching it in tandem with a new Vision 2050.

I also want to ensure that we're encouraging alternate modes of transportation. I strongly support the SAFE Streets measure on the November ballot as the best choice to fix our neglected streets and sidewalks, implement essential traffic safety improvements to benefit all road users, enhance

the environmental sustainability and climate resilience of our public spaces, and transform Berkeley's future into one where it is safe, easy, and fun to get around, regardless of age, mobility, or mode choice.

Generally, the City should prioritize actions and policies that accelerate the transition to clean energy, such as investing in renewable energy sources, promoting energy efficiency, and supporting the electrification of transportation and buildings. Additionally, the City should implement sustainable infrastructure projects, enhance green spaces, and adopt climate resilience measures to protect against the impacts of climate change. As mayor, I would support infrastructure policies, initiatives, and designs that reduce our reliance on cars, especially gas-powered vehicles. It is equally important that we prioritize a more bike- and pedestrian-friendly city while still considering the mobility of older community members or people with disabilities. My goal is to bring together climate, biking, pedestrian, disability, and transit advocates to address climate change, design our city to decrease car dependency and improve everyone's ability to move around freely and safely in Berkeley. Of course, the transition to electric vehicles cannot happen without equitable access to EV charging stations, which should be a priority in this process. We need to consider how to increase access to EV stations and solar energy to apartments.

Finally, but importantly, we must involve all stakeholders in these efforts, and work to find common ground so we don't waste valuable time and resources. For example, if a compromise could have been worked out with the restaurant association, our gas ban might still be in place in some form.

3. In your opinion, what was the most important City Council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

I think the most important City Council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years is the upzoning on the BART stations. These projects will bring many units of housing, right over BART. At the North Berkeley BART station, this was a particularly brutal fight that continues to leave some of the nearby neighbors disgruntled about the project. I'm grateful for the advocacy from the community and the leadership of some of our pro-housing Councilmembers to make this project happen. As Mayor, I will work to try and mend some of the hurt feelings around the project by welcoming these new neighbors and ensuring that there is some community building between those who will move into these projects and others in the neighborhood. We don't want a city that is divided where disgruntled neighbors continue to be resentful and separated from newcomers.

4. In your opinion, what was the most important climate or environmental issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

The most important environmental issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years is the decision to implement a ban on all new natural gas connections in new buildings. The ordinance was designed to reduce greenhouse gas emissions by favoring electric alternatives.

Had I been on the Council, I would have supported the gas ban, but I would have ensured that during the development of this ordinance, the various community stakeholders were included in the conversation. The subsequent lawsuit regarding this gas ban is a perfect example of the City needing to involve stakeholders in the process of making this decision and being willing to compromise. If the Councilmember who wrote the ordinance had been willing to listen to the concerns of the restaurant industry, Berkeley would have avoided the significant legal fees spent defending the ordinance and having to go back to the drawing board to pass a new ordinance.

5. To achieve its RHNA goals, Berkeley must continue to build homes for all income levels. These new residents will need to travel within Berkeley. Greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions from transportation comprise roughly 60% of total emissions in Berkeley.

How would you ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce GHG emissions while adding new homes?

I would ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce greenhouse gas emissions while adding new homes by tackling barriers to public transportation, supporting alternate methods of transportation, and assessing parking for all vehicles. When it comes to barriers to alternate methods of transportation, I believe that Berkeley must prioritize increasing and improving bike lanes with safety features and supporting bus only lanes. The city needs to ensure that we have safe and accessible bus stops and ensure there are benches. By developing housing in transit corridors, we are encouraging public transit ridership. I will also look at encouraging partnerships with the local transit authority to provide folks with transit passes. We also need to be increasing the infrastructure for electric vehicles, although I recognize that these vehicles have their own negative environmental impacts. We must assess the appropriate number of car spaces, ensuring that there is ample space for disabled and older folks to park, and we need to increase spaces for parking bicycles and electric scooters.

6. Walking and biking presents opportunities to help Berkeley residents reduce their GHG emissions, but safety concerns can be a major deterrent. Of the two competing street paving measures on the ballot this November, one of the major differences between the two is the approach to funding safety improvements for walking and biking.

Measure EE would provide safety funding only for traffic calming on bicycle boulevards and major pedestrian projects identified in the Pedestrian Plan. Measure FF would provide funding to implement safety measures throughout the city, based on existing plans.

What is your perspective on how we should address pedestrian and cyclist safety on our streets? What is your perspective on these two measures?

As a frequent bike-rider, and a former commuter by bicycle, I have first-hand experience with issues of safety in Berkeley. I was hit by a car while biking on Milvia Street, before the protected bike lanes. This incident was a reminder that accidents can be significantly reduced, and hopefully prevented, by physical changes to our streets with more cyclist and pedestrian-friendly infrastructure in Berkeley's arterial streets.

I believe Measure FF better addresses people's safety and well-being in its improvements to citywide infrastructure. Measure FF would allocate 30 percent of funding to street safety enhancements, which is more than twice the allocation of Measure EE's 13.5 percent. Although Measure EE incorporates 'traffic calming' measures, this does not directly address root issues affecting pedestrian and/or biker safety. We, as a city, should be thinking sustainably in the long-term and no longer rely on 'band-aid' measures. The goal is to continue expanding efforts to minimize reliance on cars overall and to encourage residents to opt for means of transportation with less carbon footprints.

Thinking especially about our neighbors with young children, wheelchair users, the elderly, the disabled community at-large, and cyclists, it is unacceptable that [42.25 percent](#) of Berkeley's streets were rated as 'poor or failed' in 2022. We, as a City, have much to work towards on improving our streets in terms of safety and accessibility. Measure FF will push us closer to actualizing improvements. I also appreciate the accountability piece through an intentional oversight body: consisting of 7 representatives with relevant expertise and sound judgment from the Transportation and Infrastructure Commission, the Environment and Climate Commission, and the City Council.

7. Berkeley has a long history of using zoning, restrictive covenants and redlining to achieve racial and economic segregation. This history continues to shape Berkeley today.

Recent research by the Turner Center at UC Berkeley suggests that inclusionary zoning requirements, which mandate on-site restricted affordable housing in new developments, may have the effect of reducing overall housing construction, including the production of affordable units. However, on-site affordable housing can also be an effective tool for desegregating neighborhoods.

What is your perspective on how Berkeley should use inclusionary zoning requirements, versus other affordable housing development options (such as in-lieu fees)?

I generally agree with our current model of 20% below-market-rate units, in-lieu fees, or a combination. I appreciate that inclusionary zoning requirements have many benefits, including increasing choices for low-income residents about where to live, helping achieve climate goals by promoting infill development and reducing sprawl, and fostering responsible development, helping to create economic growth for the surrounding community. In-lieu fees allow for flexibility, but don't guarantee additional affordable housing development and often do not reflect the full cost of affordable housing development. I think it's important to consistently revise the fee schedule in a way that doesn't deter development but still encourages more funding for affordable housing. I believe we need a balanced approach of building at every level to address our housing crisis.

8. Many of the highest income neighborhoods in Berkeley are also in the Hillside Overlay, portions of which are in the California Very High Fire Hazard Severity Zone (CalFire VHFHSZ). How should we balance fire risk with affirmatively furthering fair housing?

Concerns about fires in the hills are reasonable, and building more housing in unsafe areas doesn't make sense. Yet, not all of these streets have the same level of fire risk. Before considering how much density to allow in the hills, I want to wait for the release of the updated wildfire evacuation plan. I think it's likely that some of the areas need to be reassessed and housing can be built there. It's worth noting that some of the concerns around building in the hills are blown out of proportion with concerns about skyscrapers being built on the hills.